



PACIFIC ADMIRALS

Admiral Chester Nimitz (right) held command in the Pacific area from 1941. Vice Admiral Marc Mitscher notably led Carrier Task Force 58 in the 1944 Battle of the Philippine Sea.

At first light on May 8, the Americans sent off reconnaissance patrols and soon located their enemy. The two carrier forces were 100 miles (160km) apart. At 8:30am, about 90 US Navy aircraft took off from the carriers. As they headed for their target, the Japanese carrier aircraft headed off toward the US ships. The American fliers found the Japanese carriers in a tropical rainstorm. The *Zuikaku* slipped away into the mist, but the *Shokaku* was repeatedly hit by the American dive-bombers and was left still afloat but ablaze. Unfortunately for the *Yorktown* and *Lexington*, the sky over their patch of

ocean was clear as Lieutenant Commander Kuichi Takahashi led his Aichi D3A (Val) dive-bombers and Nakajima B5N (Kate) torpedo-bombers into the attack. As they flew into an intense barrage of anti-aircraft fire, Takahashi's aircraft was blown to pieces and so were a number of others. But too many of the airplanes got through.

It was momentarily a curiously personal close-range encounter as the torpedo-bombers came in at just above flight-deck height: a Japanese pilot remembered seeing "American sailors staring at my plane as it rushed by." Both carriers took punishment, especially the "Lady Lex." Racked by fires and internal explosions, she had to be abandoned. The *Yorktown* struggled back to Hawaii for repair. The Battle of the Coral Sea was not a



COMING IN TO LAND

A Curtiss SB2C Helldiver, the US Navy's prime dive-bomber in the last two years of the war, prepares to land on a carrier deck. For a pilot to find his way back to his carrier after a mission was by no means straightforward, especially when short of fuel.